

Chandhok asks.

“Look at the ISL. They have a set window, and it does not matter whether the Indian cricket team is playing Australia, whether there’s a World Cup, or whether there’s anything else. The ISL window is the ISL window. So, why isn’t there a kabaddi window? That July-August-September chunk that kabaddi had once was a solid space as it gave sponsors the ability to tap into a part of the calendar when not much cricket was going on. This is an indoor sport, and a monsoon window is the perfect time to slot this in for commercial value. Making that stable gives sponsors time to plan for it ahead of time too,” he adds, taking into account the reasonable adjustments that can be made in years when the Asian Games or the Olympics are on.

“All teams struggle a bit when it’s an end-of-year window as sponsors have exhausted their purses elsewhere and don’t have marketing funds to give us.”

Fostering a meritocracy

A decade is a great time to look both within and beyond.

As far as expansion goes, for several franchises, like the Warriorz who have interests in other leagues including cricket, a women’s variant of the PKL is high on the to-do list. Gupta was part of the *Star Sports* team involved in organising the Women’s Kabaddi Challenge, exhibition matches held before the PKL games, much like the now-defunct Women’s T20 Challenge ahead of the IPL.

“This is very close to our heart. We’ve seen local tournaments where women’s games are followed and attended much more than men’s games. At the state and national



level, there are no differences in organisation. But yes, it does need that jump to the league ecosystem,” he adds, hoping to see something emerge for the growing domestic and international pool of women players in the sport.

Trinadh reveals that the franchise wants to begin with a tournament at least within the Telugu-speaking states and believes that could be a different approach to building on the appetite for women’s sport in India at the moment. Chandhok also believes that a constant dissatisfaction with the product can help foster innovation continuously for an increasingly demanding audience.

While PKL came in with a simplified and television-friendly playing format, the one major change to the way the sport is played was the lobby rule change that was implemented a few seasons ago. Under the old rule, if a raider entered the lobby without touching a defender, or a defender followed the

All-rounder: Pawan Sehrawat (centre), the Indian captain and easily among the nation’s smartest raiders, often doubles up in defence.

raider into the lobby, both would be sent to the bench. The tweak protected defenders, with the passage of play ending when the raider was eliminated.

However, a defender who was completely out of the mat, with no part of the body remaining, would be out. Still, there have been multiple cases where players, who were within the peripheries of the playing area, were benched due to a lack of contact with the surface, giving rise to contentious calls and enraged debates among players, coaches and fans.

Chandhok says, “We still don’t have clarity on the rules, for example, when a player enters the midline from outside the lobby. There’s each interpretation of that rule; every day your guess is as good as mine. And I think many teams are having matches won or lost on the basis of that single rule.”

More professionalism can foster better results for the sport. Data can help that too. “I’d like to see heat mapping, heart rate monitors, data collection on raiding styles and defensive tendencies, which can add to the conversations around, and decisions made for the sport.”



« Regular broadcasting is a necessity for domestic tiers of the game. With the talent pool widening, fans should have more opportunities to discover and follow new players – Rishank Devadiga, U Mumba raider »